

June 2025

Introduction to APQC's Process Classification Framework (PCF)®

APQC's [Process Classification Framework \(PCF\)®](#) creates a common language to discuss, benchmark, and organize the work that businesses perform. In this article, you will learn:

- » What the PCF is
- » Why organizations use it
- » The difference between cross-industry and industry-specific PCFs
- » How to access process definitions and metrics for processes in the PCF

What the PCF Is

The PCF is a hierarchical list of business processes. It includes 13 high-level categories of work, each of which breaks down that work into increasingly granular units or levels: Process Group, Process, Activity, and Task.

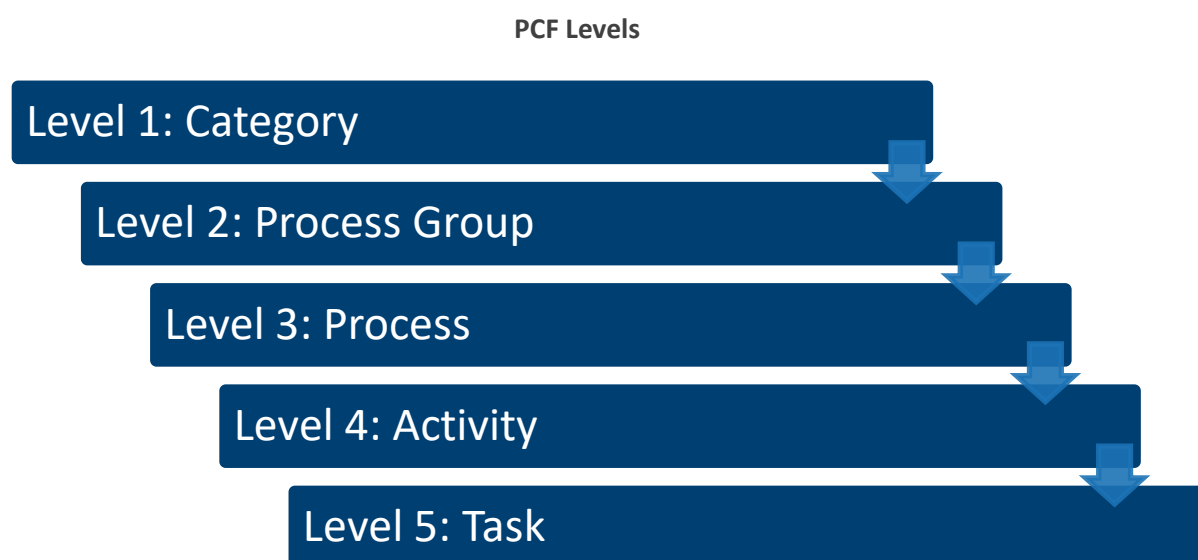


Figure 1

1. **Level 1 – Category:** represents the highest level of process.
2. **Level 2 – Process Group:** indicates the next level of processes and represents a group of processes.
3. **Level 3 – Process:** can include core elements needed to accomplish the process as well as elements related to variants and rework.
4. **Level 4 – Activity:** indicates key events performed when executing a process.
5. **Level 5 – Task:** are finer grained than activities and vary widely across industries.

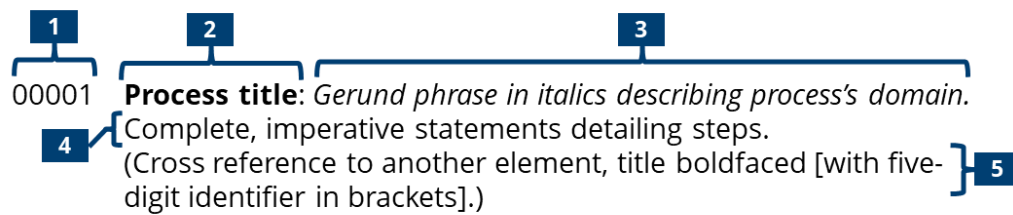
The PCF is not consistently leveled. This means that process elements at the task level in one activity may require a different amount of effort to perform than tasks in another activity at a different point in the framework. Some tasks may further be subdivided into sub-tasks.

Each element in the PCF includes five standard components (Figure 2):

1. a unique five-digit process classification ID (this allows for benchmarking even when process element names and definitions change across industries and organizations),
2. a process title,
3. a gerund phrase in italics that describes the process' domain,
4. a detailed description of the process,
5. cross references to other elements of the PCF, and
6. a process hierarchy ID that shows the location of the process within the process model (e.g., 7.0).

Example

Standard Format



Illustrative Example

10079 **Identify and refine performance indicators:** *Attuning the performance measures or products/services to better reflect the revamped portfolio of solution offerings.*
Revise the parameters used to measure performance, apropos the organization's product/service offerings.
(Modify these standards in consideration of the changes made to the portfolio by **Introduce new products/services** [10077] and **Retire outdated products/services** [10078].)

Figure 2

"We use the PCF when we are doing process improvement – to help identify interview questions, to organize work, to identify best practices, and for benchmarking."

- Quality Management Expert, Royal Philips Electronics

What the PCF is Not

The PCF is not a visual representation of the flow of work throughout an organization. It is not a process map, a flow chart, or a swim lane diagram. The PCF can be used to create those models, but a PCF by itself lacks the additional information traditionally contained within diagrams like these. This [article](#) explains more about the difference between process frameworks, maps, and models.

Why Organizations Use the PCF

Process Definition and Management

Defining processes helps organizations standardize processes and identify improvement opportunities. The PCF provides a baseline for organizations to develop their own process definitions.

Furthermore, the PCF provides a firm basis for enterprise-wide modeling efforts. The PCF provides a consistent language to bring all models together, and that language maps directly to the way that work is performed within the organization.

This reduces the effort needed to develop and manage a variety of enterprise models. The most common use of the PCF for enterprise-wide modeling efforts is in enterprise architecture, when an individual integrates a process model and a systems model to answer the question “which system does this process depend on?” or the converse, “which processes are supported by this system?” Having a centralized model such as the PCF helps to rationalize the impact of development or change across models.

Benchmarking

If you want to compare performance across your organization or against other companies, you need to have a clear definition of what you want to compare. The PCF provides a way to objectively benchmark within an organization and against other companies. The process elements’ unique reference numbers allow organizations to benchmark even when their process definitions and details differ due to industry or the unique needs of the business.

Content management

Especially in global and complex organizations, content needs to be organized so people can find what they need and work together. Organizations use the PCF as a framework for organizing content by process. For example, a checklist for controlling plant operations would be categorized under Task 4.3.2.5.1, “Automate and control plant,” or even simply under Process Group 4.3.2, “Produce Product.”

Cross-Industry vs Industry-Specific PCFs

APQC offers two kinds of PCF: [cross-industry](#) and [industry-specific](#). The cross-industry PCF is the most generic PCF: it can be applied to any organization. APQC’s industry-specific frameworks are tailored to the unique needs of different industries. For example, manufacturing is highly complex in the aerospace and defense industry. Therefore, Process Group “4.3 Produce/ Assemble/Test Product” is more in-depth in this industry’s PCF. The Aerospace & Defense PCF has 15 processes in Process Group 4.3, whereas there are only four processes under 4.3 in the cross-industry framework.

The industry-specific PCFs enable organizations to structure and define processes in a way that suits the work they perform. Industry-specific PCFs also allow for more specific and detailed benchmarking against industry peers. Importantly, though, the core PCF structure and reference numbers remain the same as the cross-industry PCF. This enables organizations to benchmark against other industries even while using an industry-specific PCF.

How to Access the PCF

APQC publishes the PCF in two formats: the Excel version and the PDF version. The Excel version is the most comprehensive format, as it includes in-line definitions of the process elements. This consistent model simplifies indexing and retrieval capabilities.

APQC also provides the PCF in a visually appealing PDF file. The PDF file lacks the level of detail present in the Excel version, but still includes the hierarchical structure. Individuals typically choose the PDF version when building consensus to adopt the framework and the Excel version when actually integrating and building models.

How to Access Process Definitions and Metrics

APQC provides [Process Definitions and Key Measures](#) for each of the thirteen categories of the cross-industry PCF. For example, Figure 3 is a screenshot from the [Definitions and Key Measures document for 4.0](#), “Manage Supply Chain for Physical Products.” It shows a definition for Process Group 4.3, related key performance indicators (KPIs), and a definition for Process 4.3.1.

Process Definitions and Key Measures

4.3 Produce/Assemble/Test product (10217)	
Processing and delivering the finished goods manufactured by the organization. Schedule the production of products. Execute the product production activities. Perform tests to oversee and ensure quality of production. Maintain records of the production process. Track lots.	
Suggested KPI	
Metric ID	KPI
104786	Total cost to perform the process group "produce/manufacture/deliver product" per \$1,000 revenue
104176	Unplanned machine/equipment downtime as a percentage of scheduled run time

4.3.1 Schedule production (10303)
Scheduling the production of final products. Generate a detailed schedule plan. Create and release production orders and lots. Schedule the planned and unplanned maintenance orders.

Figure 3

Benchmarking data for the KPIs can be accessed through APQC's [Benchmarks on Demand](#), which allows organizations to look up cross-industry and industry-specific metrics or [participate in benchmarking](#) to see exactly how their processes compare to other organizations.

If you have any questions, or would like to learn more about implementing the PCF at your organization, [contact us](#).

About APQC

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